# UNIT 1: BEGINNING YOUR JOURNEY, CAREER READINESS ORIENTATION

## TOPIC 3: POSSIBLE SELVES — BREAKING OUT OF THE BOX

**Topic OBJECTIVES:** The learner will:

- Know the definition of possible selves
- Understand that possible selves can be good or bad, driven by fear or hope
- Realize they do not have to live a limited life

**Topic OUTCOMES:** The learner will:

- Identify what is keeping them in a box, limiting their life
- Identify what will help them break out of their box to live a limitless life

**Topic ACTIVITIES:**

**I. Welcome to the Day**

Opening Quotes:

- "So often time it happens, we all live our life in chains, and we never even know we have the key."
  ~ *The Eagles,* "Already Gone"
- "You need to claim the events of your life to make yourself yours."
  ~ *Anne Wilson-Schaef* (author)
- "Your identity and your success go hand in hand. Many people sacrifice their identities by not doing what they really want to do. And that's why they're not successful."
  ~ *Lila Swell* (author)
- "First say to yourself what you would be; and then do what you have to do."
  ~ *Epictetus* (philosopher)
- "The walls we build around us to keep sadness out also keeps out the joy."
  ~ *Jim Rohn* (entrepreneur, author, and motivational speaker)

Real-World Application Check-in:

- Ask participants to share observations and thoughts.

**II. Letter Activity (attached)**

- Think of a young child you know and love — preferably a child under the age of one (definitely under the age of three). If you cannot think of a small child that you know well, and you think you will have a child one day or you have a child on the way, you can also write to your unborn child.
- After people have a chance to write their letters, ask if anyone would be willing to share their letter or a part of their letter with the group. Keep track of common themes.
- Then have young people cover the child's name at the beginning of the letter and have them put their name in that space.

Discussion Questions:

- Would you change any part of your letter if you were writing it to yourself? What? Why?
- Are the messages in these letters (full of hope and possibility) the same messages you receive in your life? Why or Why not?
- What messages do you usually receive (implicitly or explicitly)? How do those types of messages make you feel?
- Who do you hear these messages from?
- Do you believe any of those messages? Which ones?
- How would it feel to hear messages similar to the ones in the letters all the time?
- What do you do to reinforce or discourage these messages?
- What could you do to change the messages you receive?

**III. Discussion: What is possible self?**

- "Possible selves are the ideal selves that we would very much like to become. They are also the selves that we could become and are afraid of becoming. The possible selves that are hoped for might include the successful self, the creative self, the rich self, the thin self, or the loved and admired self, whereas, the dreaded possible selves could be the alone self, the depressed self, the incompetent self, the alcoholic self, the unemployed self, or the bag lady self." (Markus and Nurius, 1986, p. 954) from http://www.umass.edu/schoolcounseling/PDFs/brief5.2.pdf retrieved March 17, 2010
- The three main aspects of the Possible Self are: Hopes, Fears, and Expectations
  - What is a Hope?
    Something you would like very much to happen; a wish or a dream; something you are not sure will happen
    (from *Possible Selves, Nurturing Student Motivation*)
    To wish for something with expectation of its fulfillment
    (from www.thefreedictionary.com/hope retrieved April 29, 2010)
  - What is a Fear?
    Something that scares or worries you about the future; something you wish to avoid
    (from *Possible Selves, Nurturing Student Motivation*)
    To be uneasy or apprehensive about; to be afraid of frightened of
    (from www.thefreedictionary.com/fear retrieved April 29, 2010)
  - What is an Expectation?
    Something you would like to happen and are fairly sure will happen
    (from *Possible Selves, Nurturing Student Motivation*)
    Something considered likely or certain
    (from www.thefreedictionary.com/expect retrieved April 29, 2010)

*Possible Selves, Nurturing Student Motivation*
Hock, Schmaker and Deshler, Edge Enterprises, Inc. Lawrence, Kansas, 4th printing, 2008

## IV. Activities

### 1. T problem

Supplies: copy of puzzle pieces and scissors for each participant

Directions:

- Cut out the puzzle pieces and put them together to create a capital letter 'T'
- DO NOT give the answer — although you can offer hints
- Discussion Questions:
  - Who figured out the solution?
  - Who wanted to give up?
  - Why was it so difficult? What was most frustrating?
  - How did you deal with the frustration? Is that how you will deal with frustration at work? Is there a better way to deal with frustration?
  - How do we limit ourselves by seeing things a certain way, or doing things a certain way?
  - What are other things that limit us (in this activity or in life)?

### 2. Walk Through a Sheet of Paper

Supplies: paper (each participant will probably need multiple pieces of paper), scissors, copies of diagrams (to be handed out later in the activity)

Directions:

- Instruct participants to cut the paper so they can walk through it without ripping the paper.
- At some point — when people are frustrated and want to give up or when you start hearing 'this is impossible' over and over — hand out the copy of the diagram and have participants try again, following the diagram.
- Discussion Questions:
  - Who thought this activity was impossible?
  - Are there things in your life that you think are impossible?
  - What happens when we think something is impossible?
  - What happens when we know something is possible?

### 3. Nine Dots

Supplies: copy of the Nine Dots for each participant, pens or pencils, rulers

Directions:

- Connect the dots using just four straight lines without picking up your pencil.
- Can you do it with three straight lines?
- Observe the activity: Who gets 'stuck' in the box? How long does it take for people to 'break out of the box'? If everyone is stuck, help them think and look outside of the box.
- Discussion Questions:
  - Is this activity possible? How?
  - What makes this activity so difficult?
  - Who saw a box when they looked at the nine dots and did not want to write 'out of the box'?
  - We often create boxes and limit ourselves in ways that we don't even realize. Do you agree or disagree? Why?

**V. Discussion of Limitations and Boxes We Create**

- How do we unknowingly limit ourselves through boxes we create and/or boxes that others create for us?
- What are the things that keep us in our 'box'?
- What will help us break out of our 'box'?
- Can anyone think of an example of a person who has broken out of the 'box' they were put in? (Examples include: Malcolm X, Harriet Tubman, Jackie Robinson, Sonia Sotomayer, Nelson Mandela, Helen Keller, Lucy Stone, Susan B. Anthony, César Chávez)

**VI. Drawing Possible Self — Breaking out of a Box**

(This will be a work in progress. It does not need to be completed by the end of the day) Explain to students that they do not have to live a limited life — they can break free of the limitations (represented by the box)

- Write or draw on the sides of the box and the arrows pushing the box closed those things that limit us and keep us in our box.
  - Fears, Bad Habits, Poor Choices, Reactions, Uncontrolled Emotions, Victim Mentality, Negative Attitude, Weaknesses, Negative Peer Pressure, etc. (Tell them to be specific — fear of making a mistake, fear of losing friends, fear of disappointing my grandma, etc.)
- Write or draw on the arrow pushing the box open and the free space above the box those things that free us from these limitations.
  - Hopes, Dreams, Goals, Support Systems, Education/Learning, Opportunities, Talents, Resources, Strengths, Skills, Values, Positive Attitude, etc.
- Expectations and responsibilities might create boxes or free you — think about their impact in your life and include them in your drawing
- You can add more arrows or draw other symbols to represent both the pressures to stay in the box and the forces that will free you from these limitations.

Ask participants to share parts of their document that they feel comfortable sharing.

**VII. Video clip**

http://www.rogerknapp.com/inspire/doyoumakemeproud.htm retrieved March 18, 2010

- What did you think about the video?
- Who are we expected to be? What expectations limit us? What expectations free us?
- Do we focus on what we can't do — or do we focus on what we can do?
- What are we really good at? What are our hidden talents?
- Who nourishes our talents, encourages us, accepts us?

*Real-World Application: Think about how you act in different situations — is it the possible you or the limited you?*

Dear _____,

Welcome to the world. I hope you grow up to be _____ _____.

I want you to experience _____ _____ and to always _____ _____.

I know that you will learn to _____ and will also _____.

My greatest hope for you is that _____ _____ _____ _____.

I also want you to _____ _____ and to be _____ _____.

Love,

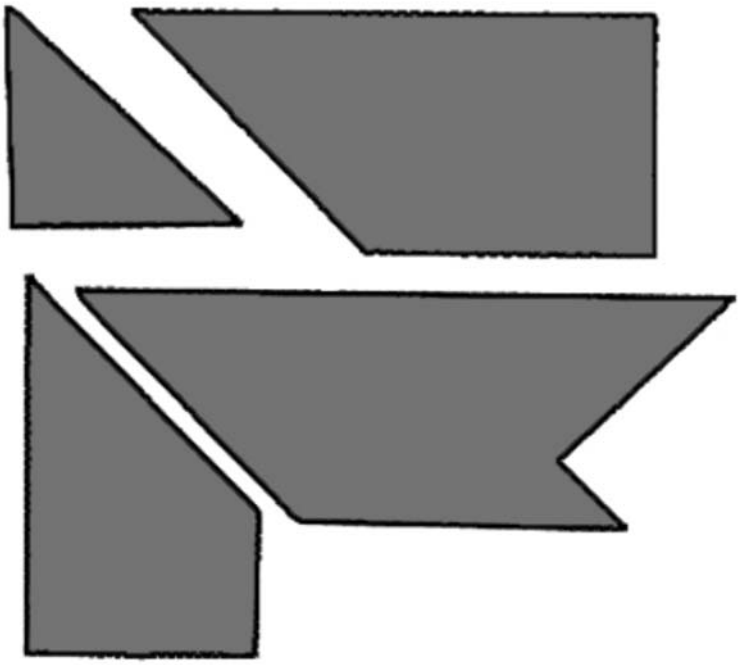
Best Initiative, The Medical Foundation, Inc.

## The T Problem

Using these 4 pieces you must make a CAPITAL LETTER 'T' with no jagged bits, no gaps, no overlaps, no bumpy bits. The solution must be all one color, i.e. don't turn pieces over. Constant manipulation is a problem solving strategy that may help you.

### Teacher Hints:

- I use this puzzle on my first day with any class. It will show you those with gritty determination, but most importantly, point out the 'learned helpless' among the group.
- Get the kids to initial all their pieces so if you lose one... you know the drill.
- Have the students store their pieces in an envelope.
- Discuss and demonstrate the problem solving strategy of 'constant manipulation.'



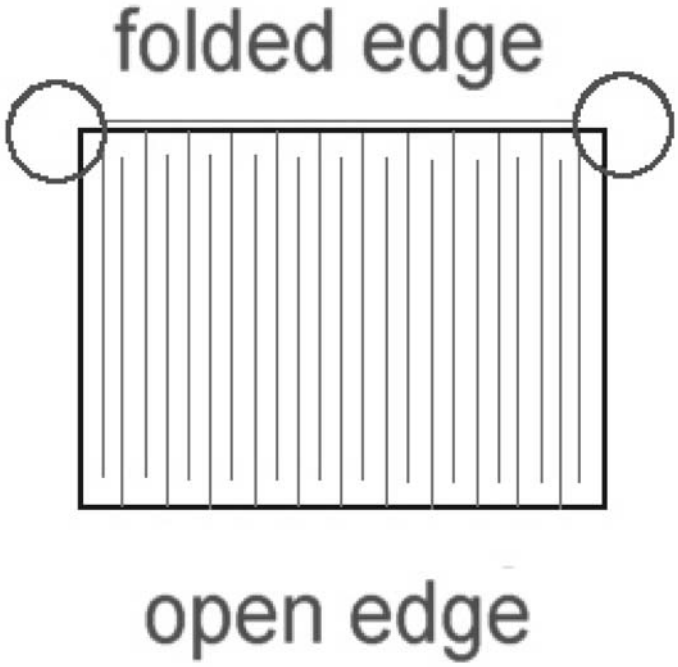


http://www.adrianbruce.com/problem-solving/puzzle1/T-problem.htm retrieved March 18, 2010

## Walk Through a Sheet of Paper

1. Give each person one sheet of paper — 8.5 x 11 and a pair of scissors.
2. Tell them that they need to cut the paper so they can walk through it without ripping the paper.

One way to cut the paper is below:



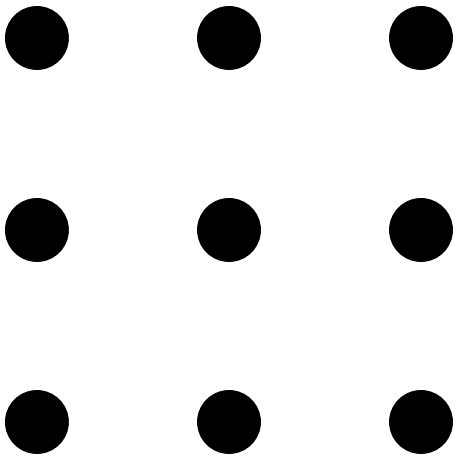

http://www.businessballs.com/freeteambuildingactivities.htm#paper-stepthrough-game retrieved March 18, 2010

## Nine Dots

Connect the dots using just four straight lines without picking up your pencil.

Can you do it with three straight lines?

(You can use a ruler if it would help)



## Breaking out of the "Box"

